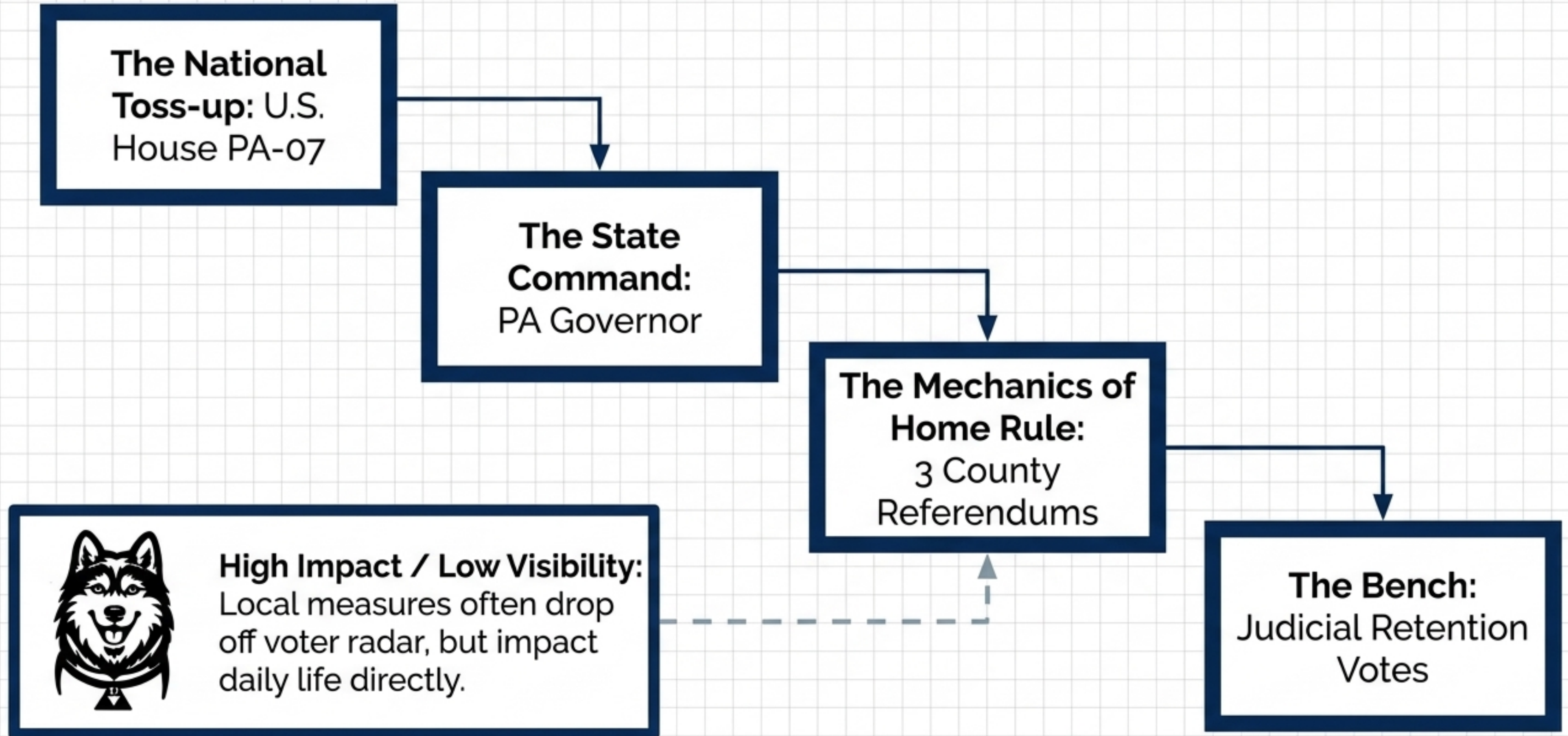




LEHIGH COUNTY VOTER PLAYBOOK

The Non-Partisan Intelligence Dossier
for the November 2026 Election.

The Non-Partisan Civic Dossier



The Federal Clash: Pennsylvania's 7th District Toss-Up

Ryan Mackenzie

Status: Incumbent (R)

Background: U.S. Rep & Former State Representative

Core Platform: Conservative economic policy, federal tax relief, border security, deregulation.

Bob Brooks

Status: Challenger (D)

Background: Former Bethlehem Firefighter (20 years) & Union President

Core Platform: Worker wage protections, preserving social safety nets, lowering everyday expenses.

Stakes: PA-07 is classified as a national toss-up district critical to U.S. House control.

PA-07 Policy Matrix: Economy & Healthcare

	Mackenzie (R) ●	Brooks (D) ●
Tax & Federal Spending	Spending cuts, deregulation, domestic manufacturing tax breaks.	Taxing billionaires, expanding worker protections and apprenticeships.
Affordability & Prices	Defends tariffs; attributes lower costs to deregulation.	Opposes tariffs; favors price-gouging enforcement and antitrust action.
Healthcare & ACA	Voted for OBBBA (~\$1T Medicaid cuts); historical opposition to ACA.	Restore ACA subsidies; expand coverage (public option/Medicare for All).

The Local Controversy: Data Center Tax Breaks



Both campaigns accuse the other of shifting positions when it became politically unpopular. Independent research is required to weigh these records.

Flip-Flop

Mackenzie's Record

Voted multiple times to give data centers tax breaks.

Campaigns aggressively against them, demanding they 'pay their fair share.'

Brooks's Record

Supported fast-tracking when backed by unions/Governor.

Opposes the projects amid heavy local pushback.

The State Command: Pennsylvania Governor

**Josh Shapiro
(Incumbent - D)**

The Investment Strategy

Infrastructure modernization, increased public school funding, preserving abortion access, workforce development.

**Stacy Garrity
(Challenger - R)**

The Fiscal Discipline Strategy

Strict corporate/income tax cuts, expanding natural gas energy, expanding school choice/vouchers.

**Ken Krawchuk
(Third Party - L)**

The Veto Strategy

Elimination of local property taxes, exercise executive veto to curb spending.

Gubernatorial Policy Matrix: Energy & Education



Energy Sector

Shapiro

The Lightning Plan

Diversified mix (Gas + Nuclear + Renewables), cap-and-invest emissions program.

Garrity

Natural Gas Prioritization

Heavy expansion of local natural gas production, fewer environmental restrictions.



Education Sector

Shapiro

Public School Funding

Focus on public school adequacy formulas; recently dropped push for private school vouchers.

Garrity

School Choice Expansion

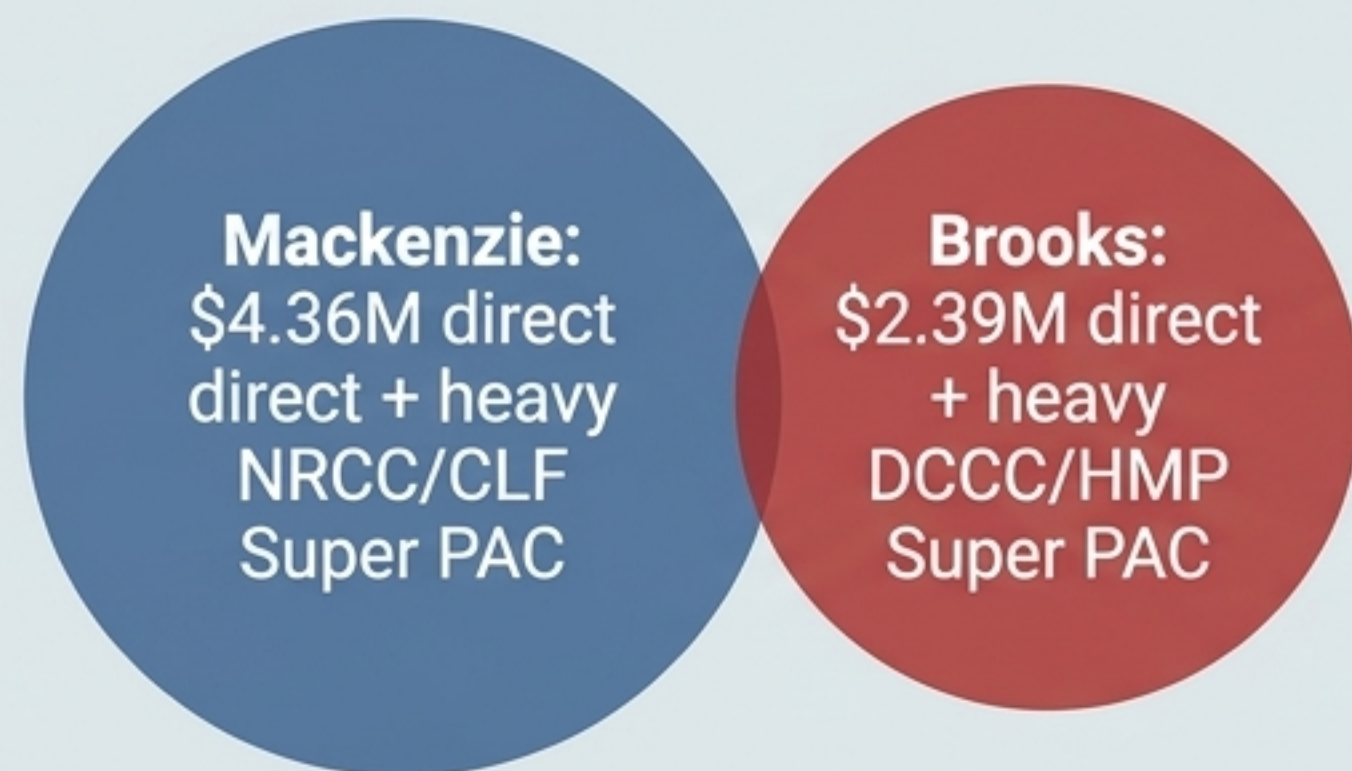
Heavy emphasis on "School Choice," steering funds toward charter, cyber charter, and private-school scholarships.

Gubernatorial Policy Matrix: Economy & Administration

	Shapiro (D)	Garrity (R)
State Taxes	Maintain current 3.07% rate; invest reserves into infrastructure.	Reduce personal income tax to 2.8%; eliminate inheritance tax.
Social Policy (Abortion)	Vocal supporter; ended state contract with anti-abortion counseling.	Historical anti-abortion record, though notes she would not sign a ban.
Election Administration	Defends mail voting; expanded automatic voter registration; resists federal voter roll demands.	Advocates stricter voter-ID and ballot rules; pledges cooperation with federal agencies.

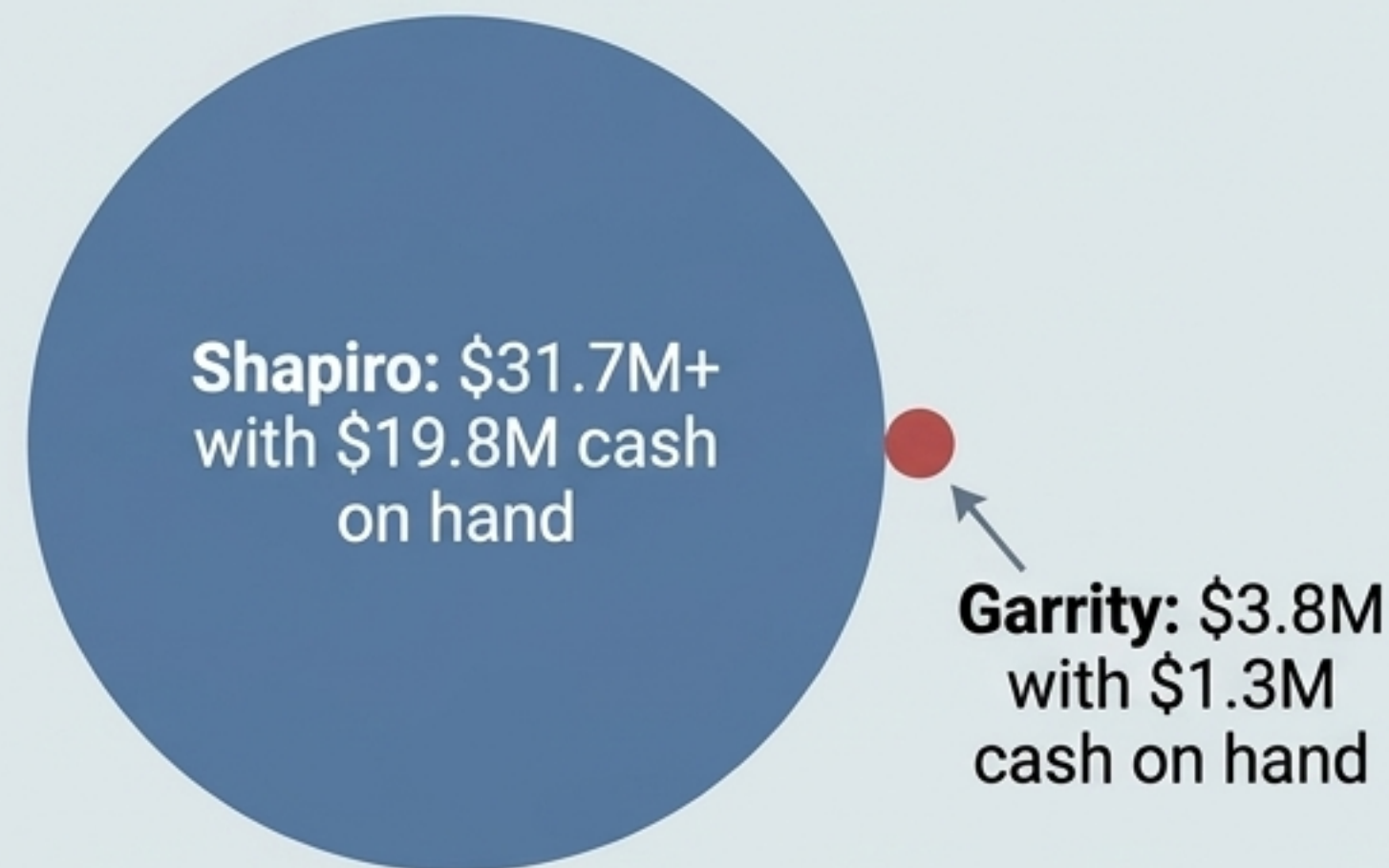
The Shadow War: The Imbalance of Spending

PA-07 Graphic - The Toss-up



Total race ~\$16M

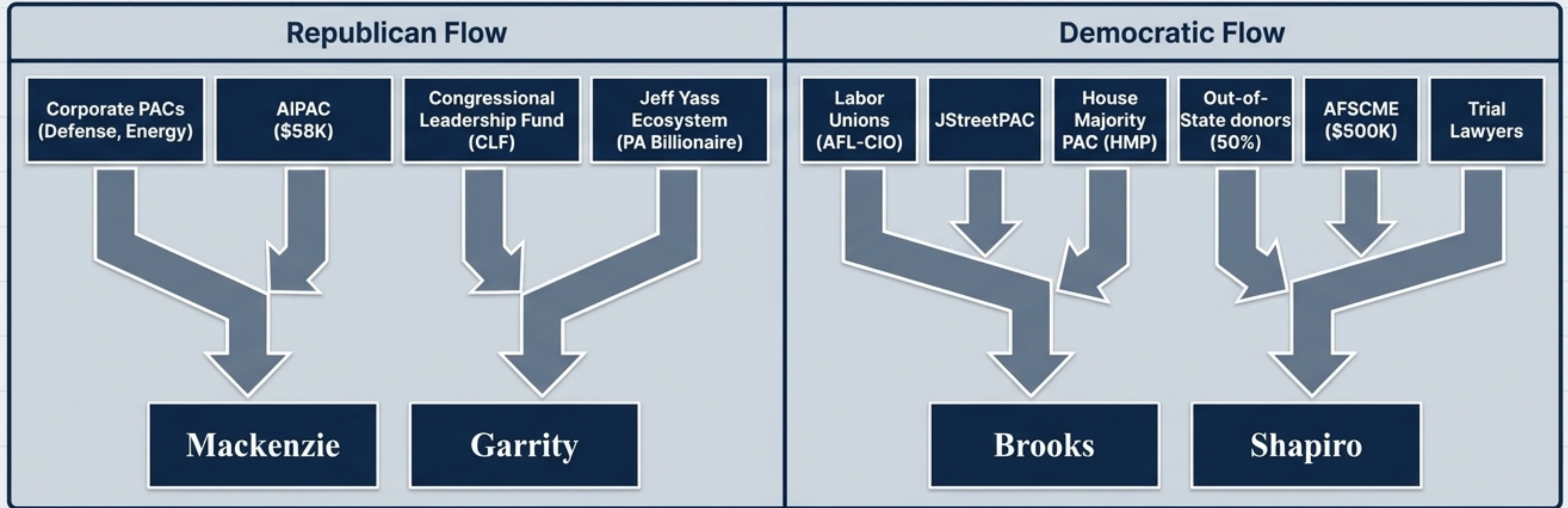
Governor Graphic - The Mismatch



An 8.3-to-1 fundraising ratio

While PA-07 is a fiercely balanced financial battleground, the Gubernatorial race operates on an unprecedented spending mismatch.

Follow the Money: Outside Influence



Watchdog Note: Super PACs obscure ultimate funders. Your vote is influenced by media campaigns funded by out-of-state entities and billionaires you never directly interact with.

The Local Blueprint: Mechanics of Home Rule

The Mechanism

Under Pennsylvania's Home Rule Charter, the Board of Commissioners (the legislative branch) cannot unilaterally change the foundational rules of county government.

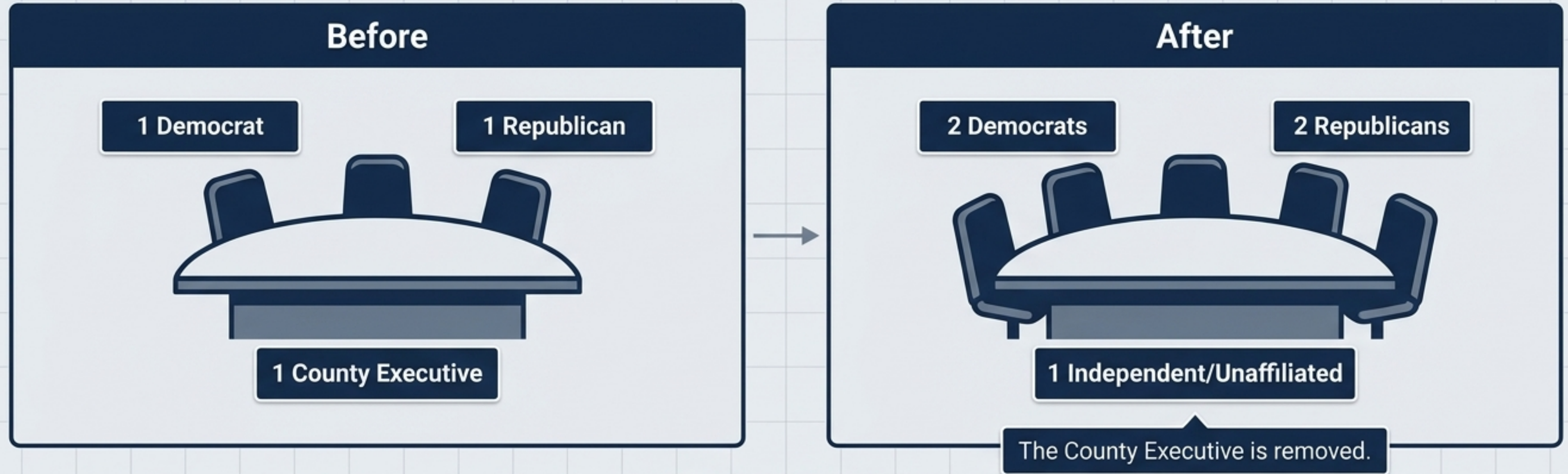


The Key

They pass the ordinance, but it requires your final referendum approval to unlock the change.

You are acting as the final check and balance on local structural power.

Question 1: Election Commission Expansion



Decision Matrix

YES Approves	NO Rejects
Giving Independent voters a designated seat, sharing the administrative workload, and removing the County Executive to avoid conflicts of interest.	Keeps the 3-member board, avoiding increased administrative stipends and concerns over how the "Independent" tie-breaker is politically vetted.

Question 2: Legal Newspaper Notices

The Proposal: Reduce the mandate for publishing official county public notices from two print newspapers to just one.



Taxpayer Savings



Public Transparency

YES Approves

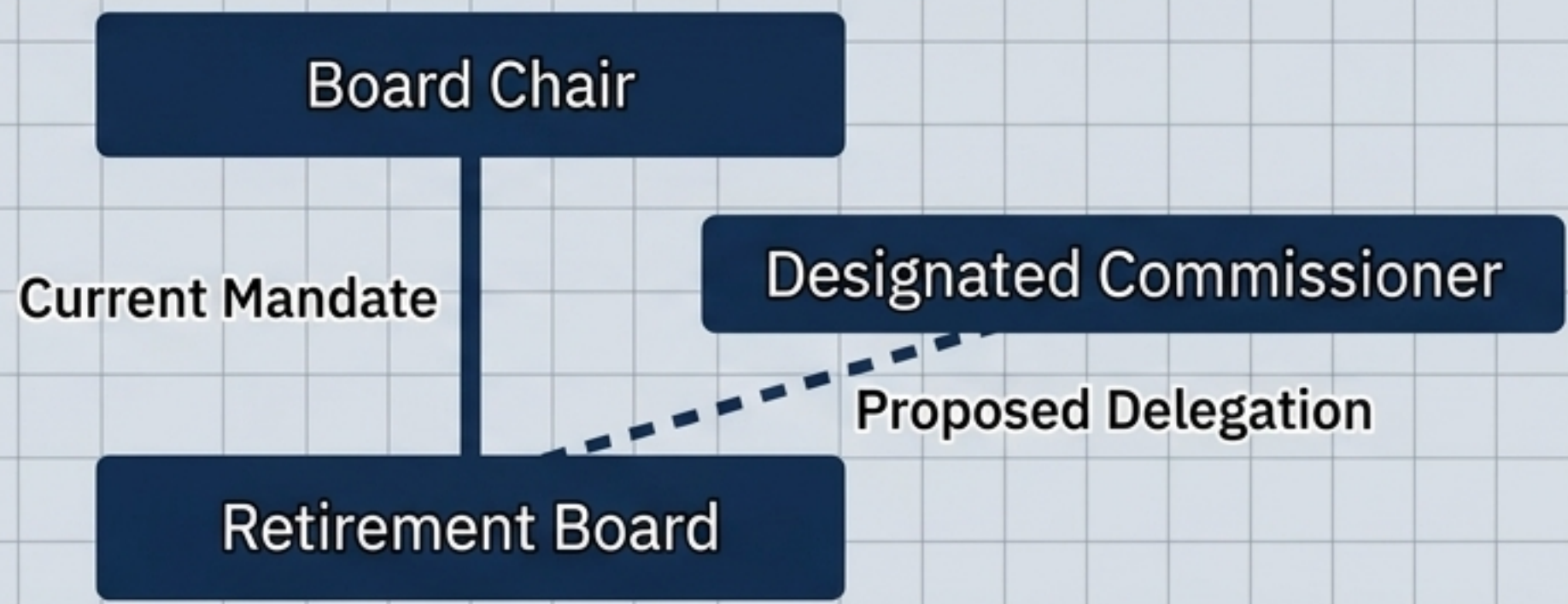
Eliminating duplicate print advertising expenses, recognizing that citizens now use digital portals for public information.

NO Rejects

Maintaining the 2-paper mandate to ensure maximum transparency (especially for elderly/non-digital residents) and preserving revenue for local journalism.

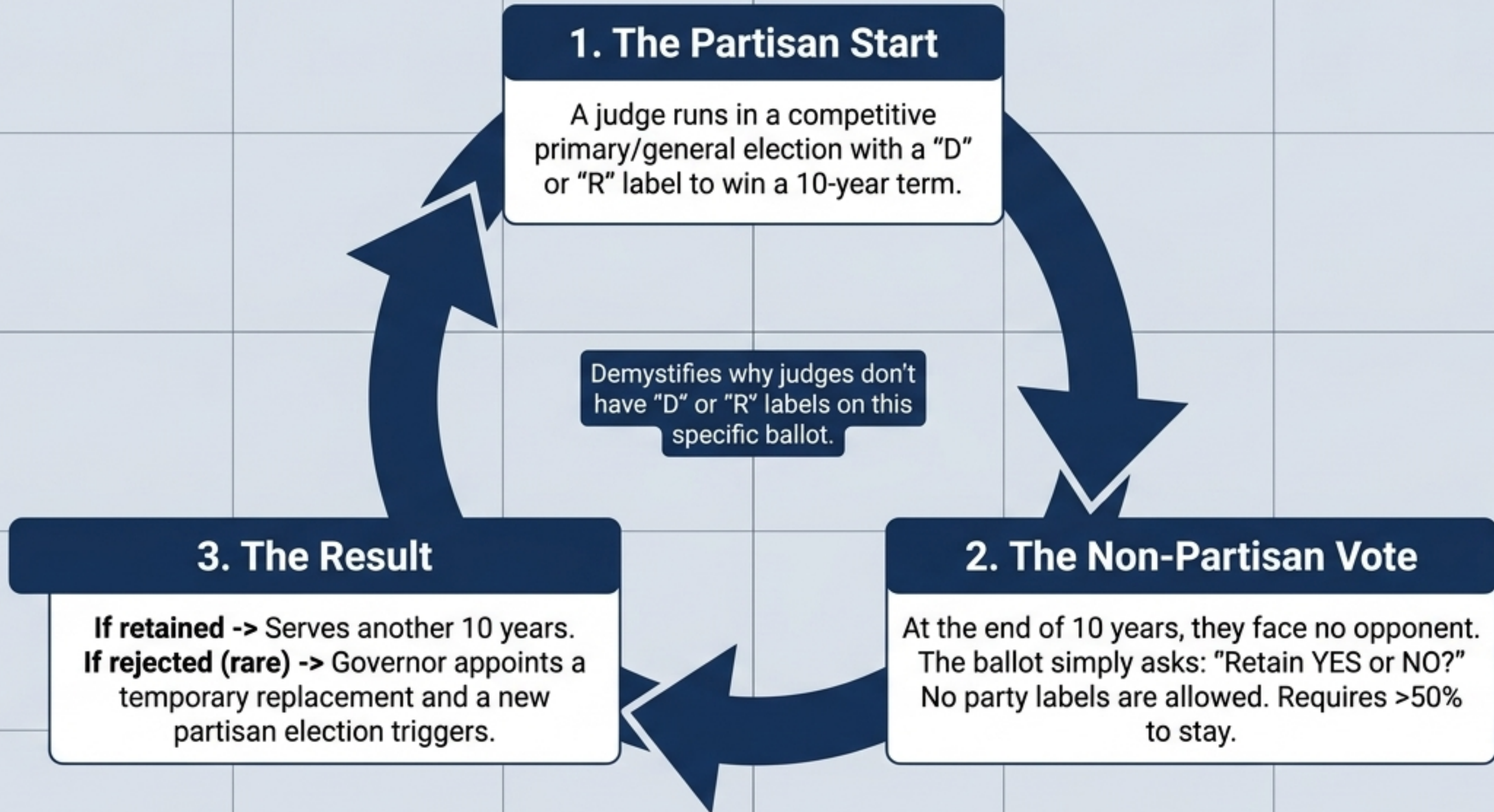
Question 3: Retirement Board Seat Delegation

The Proposal: Remove the mandate that the Chair of the Board of Commissioners personally sits on the county pension board, allowing them to designate any Commissioner.



YES Approves	NO Rejects
Flexibility. Allows the board to assign whoever has the most relevant financial/HR expertise, relieving bottlenecks for the Chair.	Direct Accountability. Demands that the highest-ranking legislative leader remains personally accountable for county employee pension funds.

The Bench: How Judicial Retention Works



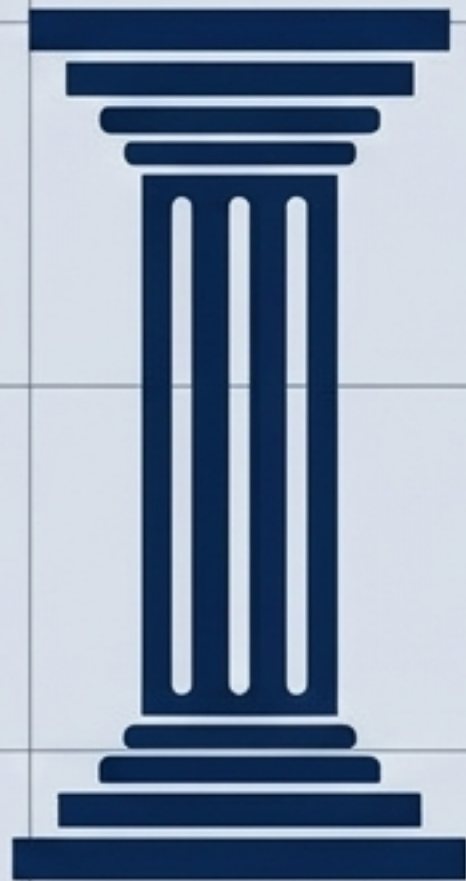
The 2026 Appellate Bench Roster



	PBA Rating
PA Supreme Court	
Christine Donohue	☑ Recommended
Kevin Dougherty	☑ Recommended
David Wecht	☑ Recommended
Commonwealth/ Superior Court	
Hon. Alice Beck Dubow	☑ Recommended
Hon. Michael Wojcik	☑ Recommended

Local Note: Lehigh County Common Pleas judges will also appear depending on your specific precinct.
Check local bar ratings.

How to Judge a Judge (The 5 Pillars)



Integrity

Impartial rulings, high ethical standards, no disciplinary history.



Legal Ability

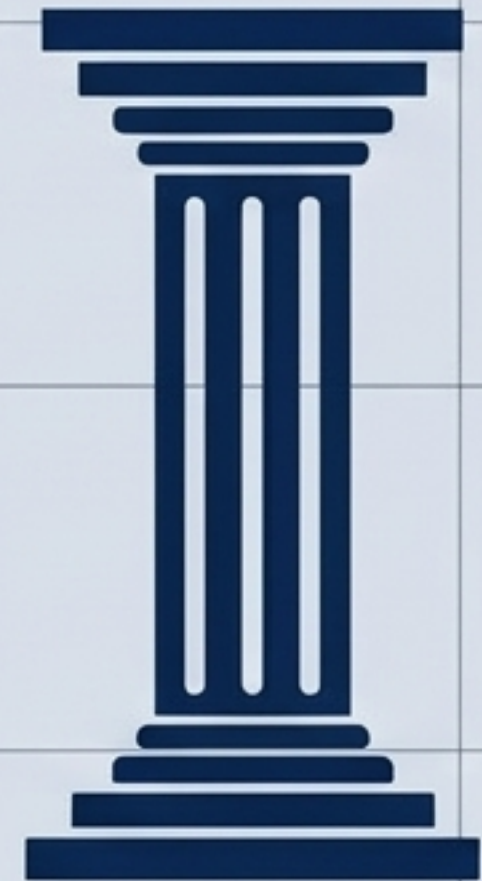
Mastery of evidence rules and clear, well-reasoned written opinions.

Temperament

Courtesy, patience, and fairness to all participants in the courtroom.

Efficiency

Decisiveness and the ability to manage dockets without excessive delays.



Service

Dedication to improving the justice system and public education.

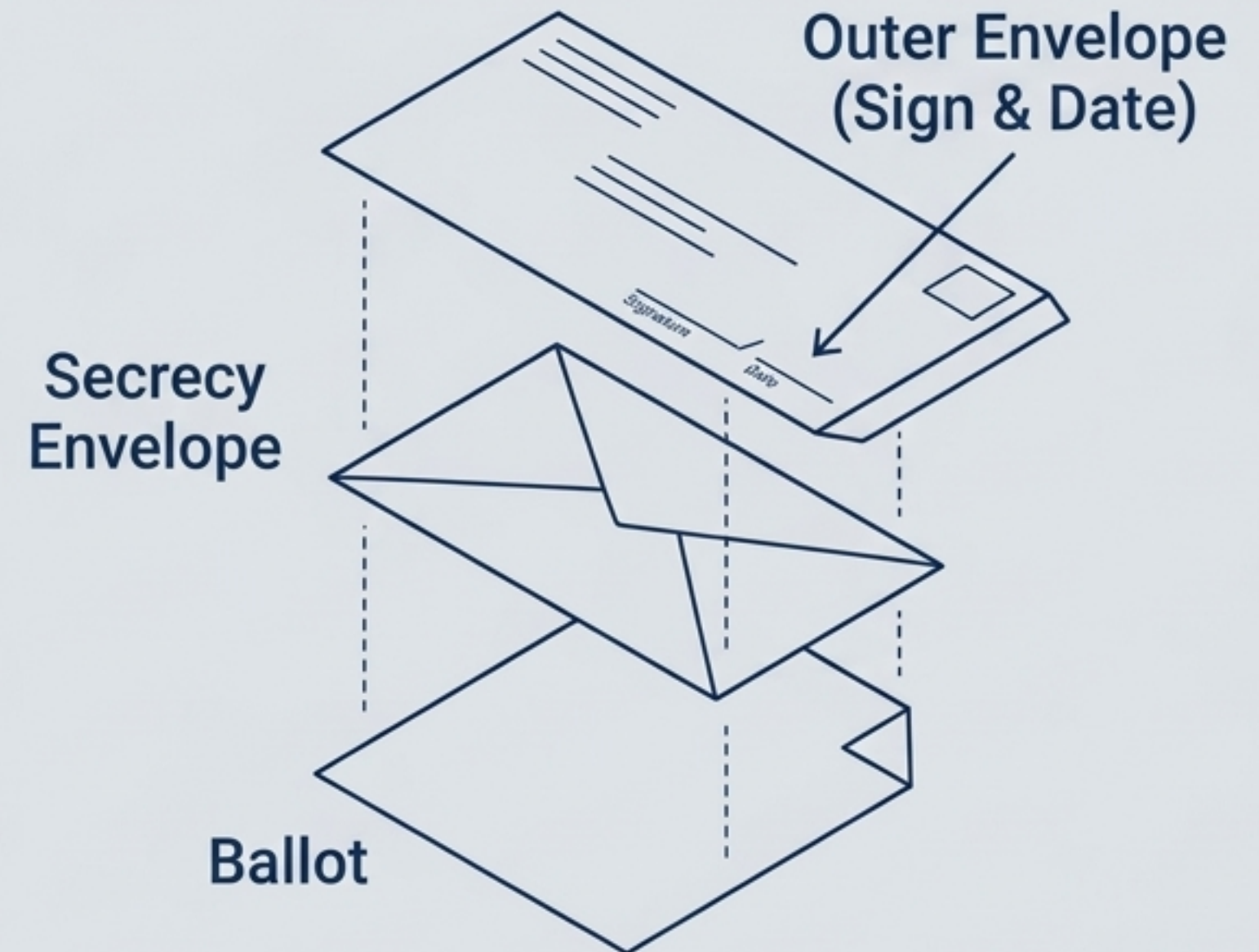
Action Plan: Phase 1 (Mail-In & Prep)

Deadlines: Verify Registration by Oct 19. Apply for Mail-in by Oct 27.

The Mail-In Checklist

- ✓ **Use Blue or Black ink only.**
- ✓ **The Secrecy Rule:** You MUST place the ballot in the blank inner secrecy envelope. Do not write on it.
- ✓ **The Outer Envelope:** Place secrecy envelope inside the return envelope.
- ✓ **Sign & Date:** You MUST sign and write the current date on the outer declaration. Undated ballots will be disqualified.
- ✓ **Return** by 8:00 PM on Nov 3.

Exploded-View Diagram



Action Plan: Phase 2 (Election Day Logistics)

Poll Hours



Polls open **7:00 AM – 8:00 PM, Tuesday, Nov 3, 2026.**

Rule: If you are in line by 8:00 PM, you have the legal right to vote.

Voter ID Requirements



Identification is required for **FIRST-TIME** voters at a precinct **only** (Photo ID or official Non-Photo ID like a utility bill/bank statement).

Returning voters do not need ID.

Contact Information



Lehigh County Voter Office:
(610) 782-3194

PA Voter Hotline:
1-877-VOTESPA

FINAL DIRECTIVE: You are legally permitted to bring this printed dossier into the voting booth as a reference sheet.